

Gunner and bombardier
Bombardier Lt William Witt sits in the nose of a B-17 returning from a mission over Germany. As well as his vital role in guiding the aircraft on its bomb run, the bombardier operated the chin gun against enemy fighters making head-on attacks.

end of 25 missions. The tension experienced by men approaching their last one or two missions was almost unbearable. Superstition flourished, men putting their faith in a treasured love letter or a lucky coin always carried with them into combat. All traces of the dead were eradicated immediately, the accepted opinion being that they were best never mentioned and treated as if they had never existed. While the ground crew remained the same month after month, air personnel changed all the time as new recruits replaced those who had failed to return. For most fliers, the bomber crew they belonged to was their major source of support and comradeship.

WINNING THROUGH

Although the strategic bombing campaign was never easy, things did improve over the course of the war. The introduction of the chin gun on B-17s, in the second half of 1943, helped to stem the losses incurred by frontal attacks. From the start of 1944, long-range escort fighters, especially the P-51 Mustang, transformed daylight bombing missions. Capable of accompanying the bomber formations to targets deep inside Germany, they imposed unsustainable losses on German fighters. In the final year of the war, German industrial production, communications, and, above all, fuel supplies were crippled by the Allied bombing campaign. But success was achieved at a heavy cost. Eighth Air Force, which operated out of England from 1942 to 1945, had one in eight of its 210,000 airmen killed; its total losses, including those wounded and taken prisoner after bailing out, were 53,000, more than one in four of its airmen. Ninth Air Force (which transferred from Italy to England in 1944) and Fifteenth Air Force also suffered heavy casualties. The men who flew in the face of such severe punishment showed outstanding courage and commitment.

COMBAT BOX FORMATION

A typical B-17 formation was based on a group of three squadrons, each consisting of six or seven bombers. The "lead" squadron flew with a "high" squadron above and to its right, and a "low" squadron below and to its left. All the aircraft were at different altitudes to allow their gunners a free field of fire.

Three groups combined to make a "wing" of 54-plus aircraft, the groups also arranged as "lead", "high", and "low". It was impossible to avoid problems at the trailing edges of this "combat box", where the rear units would be relatively exposed to attack by enemy fighters. A group of three squadrons is shown below.

